

A Plan Rejected, A War Begun

Lesson 7 — The Partition of Palestine and the 1948 War

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain why Britain referred the Palestine question to the United Nations

2

Describe the Partition Plan's terms and why it was rejected by Arab states

3

Trace the 1948 war's course and its territorial outcome

4

Begin evaluating whether war was the inevitable result of partition

An unresolved contradiction reaches its breaking point

Lesson 6 left Palestine as the one mandate Britain could not resolve. By 1947, Britain gave up trying — handing the entire question to a United Nations barely two years old.

From mandate to United Nations question

Facing continued violence between Jewish and Arab communities — including the 1944–48 Jewish insurgency against British rule — and unable to reconcile its own contradictory promises, Britain announced in February 1947 its intention to end the Palestine Mandate, referring the entire question to the United Nations.

Resolution 181: partition into two states

A UN Special Committee investigated over 1947, and on 29 November 1947 the General Assembly adopted Resolution 181, recommending Palestine's partition into separate Jewish and Arab states in economic union, with Jerusalem placed under international UN trusteeship. Jewish leadership accepted the plan; Arab states and Palestinian Arab leadership rejected it outright.

A rejection with real reasoning behind it

Arab states and the Arab League viewed partition as an unjust imposition on the Arab majority then living in Palestine, favouring recently arrived Jewish immigration over long-settled Arab communities. This was not simply obstruction: it reflected a genuine, widely shared Arab view that the plan resolved a European and Jewish question at Palestinian Arabs' expense.

Fighting begins before the mandate even ends

Violence between Arab and Jewish communities broke out almost immediately after the UN vote. When Britain's mandate formally ended on 15 May 1948, Jewish leaders proclaimed the State of Israel; the very next day, armies from Egypt, Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq invaded, beginning full-scale war.

A map redrawn beyond the UN's plan

By the war's end, Israel controlled substantially more territory than the Partition Plan had allotted it; Jordan annexed the West Bank; Egypt administered the Gaza Strip through an “All-Palestine Protectorate”. No independent Arab Palestinian state emerged at all — armistice lines from this war held as the de facto regional map until 1967.

Was this war unavoidable?

A genuine evaluation must weigh: could a negotiated alternative to partition have succeeded, given both communities' irreconcilable claims to the same territory? Or did the specific decision to reject Resolution 181 outright, rather than negotiate its terms, make war the direct, foreseeable consequence? Different historians place different weight on each.

A full essay attempt

'War in 1948 was the inevitable result of the United Nations Partition Plan.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position clearly, and identify your evaluative criterion
- Use specific facts about both the plan's terms and its rejection
- Address at least one genuine counter-argument before concluding

Key terms from today

Resolution 181

The UN's 1947 Partition Plan for Mandatory Palestine.

Armistice lines

The de facto borders that held from 1949 to 1967.

All-Palestine Protectorate

Egypt's post-war administration of the Gaza Strip.

Foreseeable consequence

An outcome that specific decisions made likely, rather than simply inevitable.

What to remember

The UN's 1947 Partition Plan was accepted by Jewish leadership and rejected by Arab states and Palestinian Arab leadership on genuine, widely held grounds. War followed almost immediately, ending with Israel controlling more territory than the plan allotted, and no independent Palestinian Arab state at all — a map that held until 1967.

Lesson 8 — The consequences of 1948

Next lesson: the refugee crisis, regional realignment, and long-term consequences that made 1948 a beginning, not an ending, for the conflict.